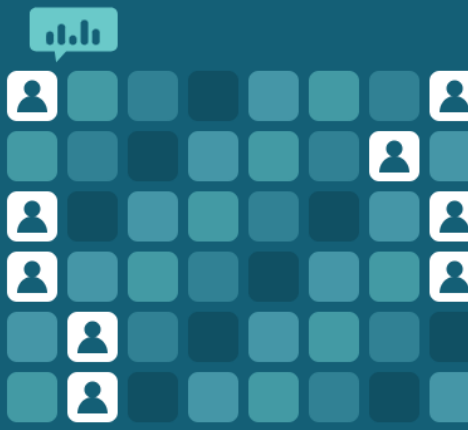
Place-based data training

Activities workbook

Module 2.3: Data literacy and interpretation



This training brings together practical guidance for using data in place-based work. It draws on PLACE and Seer Data's work alongside place-based initiatives across Australia.

The training covers the journey many place-based initiatives go on – from finding and accessing data to sharing it, making sense of it with community and using it to support local decisions and action.

Who is it for?

It is designed for people working in or supporting place-based initiatives. You might be new to working with data or already using and managing data as part of your everyday rhythm.

How to use this workbook

Throughout the training, you'll find opportunities to reflect on your work and consider how the ideas and tools apply in your place or initiative. This workbook brings together the activities for this module.

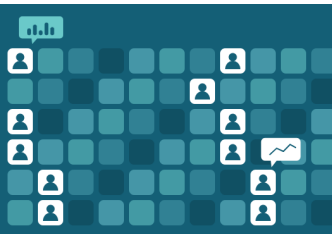
You can work through the training from beginning to end, or choose the modules most relevant to your role, experience and current work. We recommend starting with Welcome to place-based data training. You can return to other sections as you need them.

You can also connect with others doing the training to ask questions, share what you're learning and learn from their experience on PLACExCHANGE at **pxc.placeaustralia.org**.

A collaboration between

PLACE
Partnerships for Local Action & Community Empowerment

Seer
Data & Analytics



Community insights, data & stories

Module

2.3 Data literacy and interpretation

Section 1	Understand charts, trends, and indicators	2 activities
Section 2	Identify gaps, bias, and data limitations	2 activities
Section 3	Reframe challenges as opportunities for change	2 activities

Try this now: choose a chart for one real piece of work

Apply Apply to your place 1

Pick something you are working on now where you want to show data: a report, a community meeting, a funding update, or a dashboard. Then fill in the table.

1. Name the message you want the data to carry, in one sentence.

2. Choose the chart type that fits that message. Use the simple and advanced tables above.

3. Write one reason it fits the message, not just the chart you already know.

4. Run the five quality checks (accuracy, clarity, balance, context, ethics) and note one thing you need to fix (if applicable).

The message in one sentence	Chart type chosen	One reason it fits	One thing to fix from the quality checks

> Tip: If two chart types both seem to fit, choose the one that makes your main message easiest to see in about ten seconds.

Try this now: read one chart, and write one question

Apply Apply to your place 2

Choose a chart you have seen recently, from a report, a dashboard, or a news article. Then fill in the table.

1. Name the chart's parts: does it have a clear title, labels, a unit of measure, and a source? Note any that are missing.

2. Write what the numbers are saying, in one sentence.

3. Write one thing the numbers are not saying: a reason, an experience, or a group that may be missing.

4. Write one open, neutral question you could ask to better understand the data.

The chart	What it is saying	What it is not saying	An open question

> Tip: Open questions often start with "How…", "What…", "Tell me about…", or "Can you describe…".

Try this now: test one dataset for gaps and bias

Apply Apply to your place 1

Choose a dataset you use or rely on. Then fill in the table.

1. Name the dataset and what it is meant to show.

2. Name one group, place, or topic that may help you understand it more fully.

3. Choose the one type of bias, from the six above, most worth checking for in this dataset.

4. Write one question you could ask the community to help fill the gap or check the bias.

The dataset	Who or what may add understanding	The bias type most worth checking	One question to ask the community

> Tip: If you are not sure which bias type applies, start with “who was counted, and who was not?”. That question opens most of the others.

Try this now: notice one form of knowledge your data does not hold

Apply Apply to your place 2

Think about a piece of data work you are involved in. Then fill in the table.

1. Name the data work and the main dataset behind it.

2. Name one form of local, cultural, or lived knowledge that would enhance this dataset.

3. Write how that knowledge has changed, or might change or deepen, what the data seems to show.

4. Write one respectful step you have taken, or could take next, to include it, such as who to ask, or what consent is needed.

The data work	Knowledge the data does not hold	How it might change the reading	One respectful next step

> Tip: Keep names, locations, and identifying details out of the table. Some cultural knowledge carries protocols about what can be shared onward, so record only what you have permission to record.

Try this now: reframe one finding

Apply Apply to your place 1

Take a real finding from your work that is commonly framed as a problem. Then fill in the table.

1. Write the finding as it is often stated, in its deficit framing.
2. Name one strength, asset, or sign of progress that sits alongside it.
3. Rewrite the finding so it acknowledges the challenge and points to potential and action.
4. Note one word you changed, and why the new word invites action.

The finding, deficit framing	A strength alongside it	The finding, reframed	One word changed, and why

> Tip: A strengths-based reframe still tells the truth about the challenge. It adds the strength and the next step; it does not hide the problem.

Try this now: build one strengths-based reading

Apply Apply to your place 2

Take one dataset or finding you are working with. Then fill in the table.

1. Choose one of the five moves above to apply.
2. Name the challenge the data shows, stated truthfully.
3. Name the strength, asset, or progress you will show alongside it.
4. Write the next step or shared action you will end on.

The move you chose	The challenge, stated truthfully	The strength shown alongside	The next step to end on

> Tip: If you can only find the challenge and not the strength, that is a sign to bring community members into the reading before you report it.